

The Standard Did Not Change: My Journey from 09M to Becoming a Soldier

By Njai Sulaiman

August 2026 · 8 min read

When I joined the United States Army, I was not fulfilling a childhood dream. My childhood dream was medicine. The standard did not change because I had failed to meet it. I had to develop until I could meet the standard.

Why I Joined

When I joined the United States Army, I was not fulfilling a childhood dream. My childhood dream was medicine. Growing up in Sierra Leone, I remember watching Soldiers pass near our community and being drawn to their uniforms, discipline, and presence. I did not imagine then that I would one day wear the uniform myself. I pictured a white coat instead.

Years later, after immigrating to the United States and attending Prince George's Community College, the Army came back into my thinking. I was still serious about medicine, but I was also thinking about work, education, stability, and the kind of discipline I wanted in my life. I had developed an interest in cybersecurity and information technology as well. I had ambition, but my road was not straight.

My family had concerns about the Army. My mother worried about the danger. My father questioned whether I could handle the demands and told me to focus on college. I did go to college, but the idea of serving never completely left me.

By early 2026, I was ready to act on it. My older sisters, Neema and Salaymata, encouraged me. I spoke with a high school friend who had joined the Army and eventually connected with a recruiter. I had made the decision to try. Now I had to qualify.

The Standard Did Not Change

My biggest obstacle was the Armed Services Vocational Aptitude Battery (ASVAB). My Armed Forces Qualification Test (AFQT) score, which is derived from the ASVAB, did not initially meet the requirement I needed. After more than one attempt, I scored a 24 when I needed at least a 31.

That was a hard result to accept because I had confidence in myself. But confidence was not the problem. Preparation was. I had to admit that believing I could pass was not the same as doing the work required to pass.

I received another opportunity through the Future Soldier Preparatory Course (FSPC) Academic Track, entering under MOS 09M (Delayed Trainee). My days became structured around physical training, academic instruction, meals, studying, and preparation for another test.

That experience gave me a lesson I still carry: the standard did not change because I had failed to meet it. I had to develop until I could meet the standard.

This time I studied differently. I listened more carefully, practiced, and spent time on the areas where I was weak. After roughly three weeks in the program, I tested again and earned a 52 AFQT score.

Going from 24 to 52 meant I could move forward, but the bigger change was in how I approached the challenge. I learned that asking questions, accepting instruction, and admitting what I did not know were part of improvement, not signs of weakness.

Basic Combat Training: Me Versus the Challenge

Nothing completely prepared me for the first seventy-two hours of Basic Combat Training. We were moving equipment, carrying supplies, responding to Drill Sergeants, learning accountability, and trying to understand a new environment while everything seemed to move faster than we did.

At one point, our bags were dumped into a pile and we had only seconds to find the one with our name on it. Then came my first BCT shower. I had about enough time to put soap on myself before hearing that time was up. My first thought was simple: I haven't even rinsed the soap off yet. It was much funnier afterward.

Sleep stopped feeling predictable too. We could expect one wake-up time and find ourselves standing up hours earlier. In those first days, I kept asking myself, What did I get myself into? I was not planning to quit. I was realizing that wearing the uniform was very different from admiring it.

One of my hardest moments came during the Army Fitness Test (AFT) when I injured my ankle during the two-mile run. The pain turned into a mental argument: Can I do this? Can I finish this?

I had already dealt with difficult transitions — leaving Sierra Leone, adjusting to an American classroom, balancing school, work, and family responsibilities, and failing tests I expected to pass. BCT made the struggle more immediate. It was not me against another Soldier. It became me versus the challenge.

For me, resilience stopped meaning that difficulty should be ignored. It meant learning how I respond when something hurts, when I am uncertain, or when the plan is not going the way I expected.

Faith, Battle Buddies, and Leadership

BCT also tested an important part of my identity: my faith. I am Muslim, and prayer has been part of my life since childhood. My mother often asked me, “Did you pray today?” In BCT, where the training schedule controlled most of the day, I carried my prayer mat and prayed when circumstances allowed. In the field, time, location, and cleanliness could make that more difficult.

Military discipline and religious discipline are different, but I saw a connection in my own life: both ask something of me when conditions are inconvenient.

The Army also placed me beside people I might never have met otherwise. We came from different states, countries, cultures, schools, and backgrounds. During the Forge, after miles of movement and demanding training, I shared a foxhole with battle buddies. We were tired and dirty, but experiences like that turned strangers into people I considered brothers and sisters.

About two weeks before graduation, SPC Alphonse Ngandjui and I stayed up talking about BCT, life, discipline, and leadership. One idea from that conversation stayed with me: I needed to spend less time trying to speak and more time learning how to listen.

That mattered to me because once I am comfortable around people, I can talk a lot. The conversation reminded me that listening is part of learning. We also talked about leadership as being willing to step forward, accept responsibility, learn from mistakes, and help solve the problem.

From BCT to AIT

On August 27, 2026, I graduated from Basic Combat Training. Seeing my family in the bleachers was emotional. For weeks, Sunday phone calls had been our connection. They knew training was difficult, but they had not lived the early wake-ups, exhaustion, long movements, and private moments when I questioned myself.

I was proud to graduate, but I was also sad to leave the Drill Sergeants and battle buddies who had become part of my daily life. My father drove me home to Maryland. I had one night to rest. The next day, another road was waiting: Advanced Individual Training.

AIT brought a different rhythm. BCT had focused on transforming civilians into Soldiers. AIT began teaching me my job as a Unit Supply Specialist (92Y). The classroom became a major part of my day. Some concepts came quickly; others required repetition, questions, and an instructor willing to explain them another way.

AIT also gave us more personal time, although the standards remained. We still had physical training, formations, accountability, classes, examinations, and responsibilities. There was also room for humor. Near the end of class, when people were being selected to clean the hallway, laptops suddenly became very interesting. People would sit behind their screens as if looking busy enough might make them invisible.

The Army was serious. Soldiers were still human. I learned to appreciate both.

A Leadership Example at AIT

One person who has influenced my AIT experience is Drill Sergeant Guidry. What caught my attention was not simply that she enforced standards. It was the way she could enforce them and still pay attention to the person standing in front of her.

After class, she might ask how we were doing, whether we were passing, and where we were struggling. If someone failed, she wanted to understand what had happened. If someone succeeded, she pushed that Soldier to keep improving.

Watching that taught me something I want to remember: high standards and concern for people can exist together. Correction does not have to make a Soldier afraid to ask a question. A leader can expect more from people and still care about how they are doing.

What Comes Next

My Army story is still being written. Completing BCT and progressing through AIT do not mean I have reached my destination. I am still near the beginning.

My next goals are clear. I want to finish university and earn my bachelor's degree. I want to earn additional professional and military certifications, become proficient in my MOS, take on greater responsibility, and work toward promotion in the Army.

Education will continue alongside my military career. I intend to pursue a master's degree and prepare myself to apply to medical school, continuing a goal that began long before I put on the uniform.

The Army did not replace my dream of medicine. It became another part of the road toward it. I also know that none of these goals will happen because I wrote them down or because I want them badly. I will have to earn the grades, meet the requirements, keep developing as a Soldier, and continue learning from the people around me.

09M taught me that the standard would not change for me. BCT showed me how I respond when I am physically and mentally challenged. AIT is teaching me that knowing my job and developing as a leader require continued learning. What comes next will test whether I can carry those lessons into my unit, my education, and my pursuit of medicine.

I do not see BCT graduation as an ending. I do not see AIT as an arrival. I do not see one degree, certification, or promotion as the finish line.

Each one is another step. The road ahead is still long, and I am still becoming.